GLOSSARY

akali	A strict and militant follower of Sikhism. In this period the term was used especially of nihangs, an armed Sikh military order who spearheaded attacks on the enemies of the Sikh religion. The word derives from Akal, the Eternal One or Supreme Being of the Sikhs.
alam	A battle standard, also used by Shias as the focus for their Muharram venerations. Usually tear-shaped or fashioned into the shape of a hand, they are highly ornate and beautiful objects, and the best are among the great masterpieces of Islamic metalwork.
amir	Commander, a shortened version of Amir al-Muminin, the Commander of the Faithful.
beg	A chief or ruler.
boosa	Hay or fodder.
chela	A disciple or pupil.
dak	Post, letters (sometimes spelt ‘dawke’ in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries).
Dasht	Literally ‘meadow’. The area that stretches from Spin Boldak at the foot of the mountains south of Kandahar.
dharamasala	A pilgrims’ resthouse.
diwan	Government office.
dhoolie	A covered litter.
durbar	A royal court.
fakir	Literally ‘poor’. A Sufi holy man, dervish or wandering Muslim ascetic.
fatwa	A legal ruling.
firangi	A foreigner.